



A Ray of Hope

An electronics vendor makes a hybrid car and contests Assembly elections to popularise an eco cause

■ **By Stephen David**

The race to make hybrid cars gets bigger by the day. The latest entrant is Syed Sajjad Ahmed, 54, from south Bangalore. He, as one of 16 candidates contesting the May assembly elections from Chamrajpet constituency in Bangalore district, showed his commitment towards the cause to popularise solar cars by listing his name as Sajjad Ahmed Solar Car on the Election Commission site. Ahmed lost the poll but gained a following of environmentally-conscious citizens who support his dream and are helping him popularise his homegrown invention, a roughly 400-kg solar car or cart, as he calls it.

Taking cue from a Swiss schoolteacher and maverick inventor Louis Palmer, 36, who has travelled over 37,000 km to spread the word about his two-seater solar-powered vehicle, Ahmed has driven his cart to cities like Chennai (400 km), recharging his solar battery every 50 km. He says with fuel prices skyrocketing, it is time to go after non-conventional energy in a serious way.

Ahmed's contraption can seat four people and can travel at 40 km per hour. Its running cost is 30 paise a kilometer and is roofed with three solar panels and one on the bonnet. The prototype's manufacturing cost is Rs 1 lakh "but can be brought down if produced on a larger scale".



Fortunately, Ahmed's passion has found the support of bodies like the Centre for Environment Education and the United Nations Development Programme's small grants programme, along with the city's Raman Research Institute and Karnataka Renewable Energy Development Limited (KREDL). This small-time electronics vendor's dream has been driving him for more than 30 years. He has also experimented with turning commercially-manufactured mopeds into solar-powered ones. In June 2006, he won Rs 1 lakh as part of the Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Parisara Prashathi. Ahmed spent most of the amount in elections and would have "liked if big political parties would have supported his cause".

"Most of the solar cars available now are demo-vehicles or engineering exercises but it won't be long before they become daily transport vehicles," says Leo Saldanha, environmental analyst, of the policy advocacy and research body the Environment Support Group. "All efforts have to be made to tackle the energy crisis and promote renewable energy," says V.P. Hiremath, managing director, KREDL, which supports Ahmed's efforts. A prototype of the car is even parked at KREDL's energy park. Ahmed looks forward to the day when drivers just bet on sunshine to take them all the way to their destinations and further.